

Strategic Auction Blueprint

Rajasthan Royals / IPL 2026 Campaign

Team Analytics | Hackathon Submission

November 22, 2025

Executive Summary

Entering the IPL 2026 auction, The Rajasthan Royals must use their meager budget of **INR 16.05 Cr** to rectify three significant roster shortcomings. Our goal shifts from foundational squad building to targeted impact optimization once we have a retained core. In particular, the team needs to strengthen the lower-middle order with a high-strike-rate finisher in order to offset the loss of lead spinner Yuzvendra Chahal.

Our suggested approach is based on the "Stars and Scouts" mentality. We suggest a precise capital allocation: using 95% of the budget to acquire two proven match-winners, **Andre Russell** and **Ravi Bishnoi**, while using proprietary data modeling to acquire **Akshat Raghuvanshi**, a high-value uncapped batter found through thorough domestic league analytics. This strategy greatly improves the team's "Wins Above Replacement" (WAR) forecast while guaranteeing adherence to all squad rules.

1 Methodology: Data-Driven Precision

We created a "Master Dataset" by refining raw auction listings and performance logs from the 2023–2025 cycle in order to find undervalued assets in a crowded market. Our data pipeline used three separate transformation stages to prioritize signal over noise

- **The Aggregation Protocol for "One-Row"**: High variance characterizes Twenty20 cricket. We created stable, reliable indicators by compressing detailed, match-by-match performance logs in order to combat this. We created a single, combined performance vector for each player by substituting **Median Strike Rates** and **Average Economy Rates** for noisy time-series data.
- **Market Value Normalization**: We discarded historical pricing volatility (2023–2024 trends) in favor of a snapshot valuation. By filtering for only the **2025 Clearing Prices** and highest bids, we aligned our financial modeling strictly with current market demand rather than obsolete historical data.
- **Signal Isolation**: We systematically removed team-dependent variables (such as match results) and "Player-Competition" mappings. This dimensionality reduction ensured that our model evaluates intrinsic individual capability ("Wins Above Replacement") independent of previous squad strengths.

This refined data foundation powers our **Weighted Utility Model**, which ranks players based on tactical fit:

- **Weighting by Role**: For finishers, we prioritize "Boundary Percentage" over "Batting Average."
- **Recent Form Bias**: A decay factor is applied to historical stats, ensuring capital is allocated based on 2024–25 performance.

2 Target Analysis & Rationale

2.1 Target 1: Ravi Bishnoi (Indian Spinner)

Role: Lead Wicket-Taking Spinner | **Allocated Bid**: INR 8.80 Cr

The Strategic Fit: The franchise's top goal is to replace a legendary character like Yuzvendra Chahal. With 91 wickets and an economy rate of 7.75 during the evaluation period, Ravi Bishnoi is ranked by our model as the top available Indian spinner.

Why Him? Because it keeps the final Overseas slot for a power-hitter, securing a domestic spinner is a tactical necessity. Ravindra Jadeja’s conventional spin is perfectly complemented by Bishnoi’s quick-arm action, which creates a trajectory that skids off the surface. Together, they create an oppressive alliance suited to the circumstances of Jaipur.

2.2 Target 2: Andre Russell (Overseas Finisher)

Role: Death Overs Finisher | **Allocated Bid:** INR 6.45 Cr

The Strategic Fit: From the 16th over on, the team needs a batter who can instantly change momentum. With a T20 strike rate of **160.00**, Andre Russell continues to be the gold standard for this particular role.

Why Him? Russell offers a special dual utility. In addition to his exceptional finishing, he provides Sandeep Sharma with death-bowling insurance. In order to prevent opposition bowlers from settling, a middle-order sequence of *Samson* → *Parag* → *Hetmyer* → *Russell* establishes a relentless offensive line.

2.3 Target 3: Akshat Raghuwanshi (The Value Asset)

Role: Middle Order Aggressor | **Allocated Bid:** INR 0.80 Cr

The Strategic Fit: This choice illustrates our analytics’ return on investment. Our model identified Akshat Raghuwanshi as a statistical outlier, despite the market’s emphasis on capped players. He has demonstrated exceptional performance in recent domestic circuits (such as the MP T20 League), averaging **52.62** with a strike rate of **160.03**.

Why Him? He offers elite output at a base-price valuation, which is a classic "Moneyball" arbitrage opportunity. He is far more economical than capped alternatives, even with a buffer of up to INR 0.80 Cr, freeing up the required funds to buy Russell and Bishnoi.

3 Financial Execution Plan

We have created a rigorous tiered budget that prohibits overspending on any one asset in order to guarantee disciplined spending.

Priority	Target Player	Squad Role	Max Bid Cap
1	Ravi Bishnoi	The Spin Anchor	INR 8.80 Cr
2	Andre Russell	The X-Factor	INR 6.45 Cr
3	Akshat Raghuwanshi	Value / Depth	INR 0.80 Cr
Total		Total Expenditure	INR 16.05 Cr

Table 1: Final Budget Allocation Strategy

4 Impact on IPL 2026: Conclusion

This auction strategy methodically resolves the Rajasthan Royals’ structural problems. We use deep analytics to identify a high-potential domestic batter, replace Chahal with a dynamic Indian spinner, and add a global superstar to bolster our finishing firepower. This team is economical, well-balanced, and built to contend for the IPL 2026 title.

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GitHub: https://github.com/smartplay28/rr_hackthon